Epilogue: The Future of Eastern Europe

In 1945, Communism forced Ljubo, Karl and many other Eastern European political emigrés to seek shelter in Western Europe. At that time, these refugees did not realise they were leaving behind ‘Eastern Europe’. There was no such thing then. They felt that – after the nightmare of Nazi and Fascist terror – their own countries had been overtaken by another alien ideology that was so opposed to everything they knew from before that life became unbearable. These were Karl’s words exactly: he could not stand the Communist regime’s uniformity, which was so alien to him. This new ideology was (literally) after their lives – Ljubo was sentenced to death, a fate he only narrowly escaped. Many others who stayed at home felt much the same, if not perhaps so intensely. There were also so many that did not have the means, the opportunity or simply the courage to leave, but few of them were comfortable with the new system. It was certainly not something that they, by the mere fact of being Eastern Europeans, could put up with. One can hardly compare the sense of frustration and desperation of those that left and of those that stayed on.

Where is Eastern Europe today? What do we know about it? Low-cost airlines have done part of the job. Many (young) people have since visited the region, which is now much more familiar to them than even a decade ago. But has Eastern Europe indeed become a normal place? And what about populism and social conservatism there, of which we can read almost daily? Are these inherent features of this part of Europe? Is there, after all, indeed something *Eastern* about Eastern Europe, as the first edition of this book was asking? Is Eastern Europe indeed the cradle of the so-called illiberal Europe, as analysed in this new edition?

With the help of the EU Single Market, EU funds, and despite the drain of many young people, the region has weathered the multiple crises of the last two decades with surprising resilience. The goals for which they fought for so long – membership in the EU and NATO, the Eurozone and Schengen – have been achieved and are now seen as a means to an end, rather than as goals. Over almost two decades of EU membership, Central Europe has grown into an assertive, economically viable and prosperous, politically